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Genesis

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Genesis

Overall Theme: Genesis begins with the story of creation and ends with the nation of Israel in Egypt. The book is sometimes referred to as where the seeds of major themes of the entire Bible are planted that will find a harvest in the New Testament.

A. Chapters one through five. Creation to Noah

1. Creation of heaven and earth (1:1-2:6).
2. Purpose of man: created as God's image bearers (1:26).
3. The garden of Eden and creation of Adam and Eve (2:7-25).
4. Temptation, sin and its result (3:1-24)
5. First promise of redemption (3:15). Salvation typified by God clothing Adam and Eve with animal skins that required the shedding of blood (3:21). This sets the standard that salvation is all of God's doing not of man's works.
6. Abel's offering to God of animals was accepted over Cain's offering of the fruits of his labor (4:1-5). This again shows God's standard of blood sacrifice over man's works. The first murder (4:8) and its consequences.
7. Adam's genealogy to Noah (5:1-32).

B. Chapters 6 through 11. The wickedness and judgement of man.

1. The sons of God mate with women (6:1-4) producing giants (the Nephilim).
2. The wickedness of man causes God to purpose to destroy mankind but spare Noah and his family by means of an ark (6:5-8:19). Peter references the ark as a type (figure) of baptism where eight souls were saved through (not by) water (1Peter 3:20-21).
3. God promises not to destroy every living thing again (8:20-9:17) and His covenant with Noah (Noahic covenant) symbolized by the rainbow (9:14).
4. The descendants of Noah and where they settled (10:1-32). This is called "the Table of Nations".
5. Man determines to build a tower (Babel) as a memorial to their pride rather than God's glory (11:1-4).
6. God confuses their language, and they begin to scatter across the earth (11:5-9).

C. The story of Abraham (15:1-25:13).

1. God calls Abram out of Haran and gives him the Abrahamic Covenant (12:1-3) which promises to make of him a great nation and through him all the families of the earth will be blessed.
2. God gives Abram the Palestinian (land) Covenant promising to give the land to his descendant forever (13:14-17).
3. Abram's nephew Lot is captured (14:12). Abram and his 318 trained servants pursue and defeat the invading armies (14:13-16).
4. Abram is met by the King of Salem (ancient Jerusalem) Melchizedek the priest of the Most High God (14:18) who blesses him (14:19-20). The fact that Melchizedek has no biographical or genealogical information given him, whose name means "{righteous king", allows him to be used later in Scripture as a type of Christ (Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 7:17,21). That he brought out bread and wine (14:18) prefigures the victory of Christ over the grave that we celebrate with communion.
5. God confirms His covenants (15:1-31) with Abram (both Abrahamic and Palestinian-land). Abram believes God and it is accounted to him for righteousness (15:6). The Apostle Paul quotes these words as an illustration of faith over works (Romans 4:3, 9, 22; Galatians 3:6).
 Note: The ritual of 15:9-18 was a practice in the ancient middle east where two parties would walk through the carcasses of animals to confirm a covenant. That Abram fell into a deep sleep and did not participate in the ritual with God, signifies that the responsibility to fulfill the covenants was entirely God's. This means that the covenants will be accomplished and are irrevocable.
6. Due to a lack of faith in God's promise that through him a son would be born, his wife Sarai gives him her maid Hagar as a wife (16:3-4). Hagar bears Ishmael when Abram is 86 years old (16:15-16).
7. God appears to Abram when he is 99 years old and confirms His covenants with him by changing his name to Abraham (17:1-8). He promises that he and Sarai will have a son and will be named Isaac (17:19). The covenant was confirmed by Abraham through circumcision (17:10-14; 23-27).
8. The Lord accompanied by two angels appears to Abraham by the trees of Mamre (18:1-2). This appearance is considered to be what is called a Christophany or pre-incarnate appearance of Jesus Christ. The Lord promised to return at the "time of life" and that Sarai will have a son (17:10).
9. Abraham bargains with the Lord over sparing Sodom (18:22-32).

0. Sodom is destroyed after Lot and his two daughters are taken out of the city. Lot's wife is turned into a pillar of salt for looking back. Lot's incestuous relationship with his daughters results in the people of Moab and Ammon (19:1-38).
1. Abraham's lack of faith in God's protection of Sarai results in Abimelech King of Gerar taking her. Abimelech acts more righteously than Abraham according to a dream from God and restores Sarai to Abraham. Abraham prays for Abimelech and he and his household and they bore children (20:1-18).
2. Isaac is born to Sarai in her old age (21:1-7). Hagar and Ishmael are cast out into the wilderness, but God promises Hagar that Ishmael will become a great nation (21:1-18).
3. God tests Abraham by instructing him to offer Isaac as an offering (22:1-19). This is a profound chapter as it prefigures Christ's substitutionary sacrifice on the Cross for us. It is worth the time spent to discuss the symbolism in this chapter of three days journey (three days in the tomb), two other men accompanying them (two thieves on the Crosses) and the location of Mount Moriah where Jesus would be sacrificed 2,000 years later. Abraham's brother Nahor has children in Haran including a grandchild Rebekah who would later become Isaac's wife (22:20-24).
4. Sarai dies, Abraham purchases the cave of Machpelah from the sons of Heth who were Hittites (23:1-19). This would later become the burial place of Isaac, Rebekah, Leah and Jacob.
5. A bride for Isaac (24:1-59)
6. Abraham dies and is buried in the cave of Machpelah (25:7:7-10). Birth of Jacob and Esau and Esau sells his birthright for a meal of lentils and bread (25:24-34). We too can sell our birthright which is to rule and reign with Christ by sinning willfully without repentance after salvation. This is not to lose our salvation but rather loss of rewards at the Bema Seat of Christ (2 Corinthians 5:10; Romans; Revelation 22:12).

D. Isaac, Esau and Jacob (chapters 26-36)

1. The Lord confirms the Abrahamic and Palestinian (land) Covenants to Isaac (26:2-5). Isaac sins as did his father Abraham by telling the people of Gerar that Rebekah is his sister. Abimelech again acts righteously and pronounces a death curse on anyone who would touch her (26:6-11).

2. Jacob deceives Isaac into believing that he is Esau and receives the blessing (27:1-29).
3. Jacob leaves for Padan Aram his uncle's house Laban. Along the way at Bethel he receives the vision of angels descending and ascending on a ladder. There, the Lord confirms to him the Covenants given to Abraham and Isaac of the land and blessing to all peoples (28:6-13).
4. Jacob marries Leah and Rachel. His wives compete with each other in bearing children along with their maids who are also given to Jacob as wives. Jacob's flocks increase while he tends Laban's flocks. He returns to Bethel with his extended family of four wives, 11 sons and one daughter. On the way, he wrestles with God who changes his name to Israel. Rachel gives birth to Benjamin and dies in childbirth. Reuben, Israel's first-born sleeps with his father's concubine and Israel hears of it. Isaac lives to 180 years and dies. Esau's descendants are listed (chapters 29-36).

E. Joseph in Egypt (chapters 37-50)

1. Joseph dreams where his brothers and parents bow to him. This angers his brothers and they conspire to sell him into bondage to a caravan going to Egypt. Israel is told that a wild beast has killed him. He becomes steward of Potiphar, Captain of Pharaoh's guard. (37:1-36). Potiphar's wife attempts to seduce him but when Joseph rebuffs her, she becomes angry and accuses him of assault. Potiphar throws him into prison but there, due to his diligence he prospers and is assigned complete control of the prison by the warden (39:1-23).
2. While in prison, he interprets the dreams of Pharaoh's baker and cupbearer. His success in interpretation he attributes to God. The baker is killed and the cupbearer is restored to his former position where he later tells Pharaoh about Joseph's ability to interpret dreams. Joseph interprets Pharaoh's dreams of seven years of bountiful harvest followed by seven years of famine. Pharaoh places Joseph in charge of all of Egypt and he builds storage cities where the harvest is stored. Two sons, Manasseh and Ephraim are born to Joseph from his wife, the daughter of an Egyptian priest. During the famine, all the known world came to Egypt to buy the grain (chapters 39-41).
3. Due to the famine, Joseph's brothers are instructed by Israel to go to Egypt to buy grain, they do not know that Joseph is their brother. Eventually, he is revealed to them and all of Joseph's brothers, their wives and children and livestock with

their father go down to Egypt where they settle in the land of Goshen (chapters 42-48).

4. Israel knows he is about to die so he gathers his sons to prophesy over them. The prophecy over Judah is particularly profound as it foretells of the Messiah to come (49:8-12). Israel dies and is carried to the family burial place, the cave of Machpelah. Years later, Joseph dies at the age of 110 and is buried in a coffin in Egypt after instructing the Israelites to take his bones back to land promised when they leave Egypt (chapters 49 and 50).

III. Discussion Questions and Application. Not only answer the questions below, but present the information to another classmate or to a friend or family member what you have learned.

- A. The first chapters of Genesis present Eden, the tree of life and a river. The last chapters of Revelation present Eden restored with trees and a river. What other “seeds” do you see planted in Genesis that come to harvest later in Scripture? Consider terms like, Redemption, Justification, Faith, Judgement. As you may not be familiar with all of Scripture, get help from your instructor.
- B. Chapter three tells of man’s temptation and fall into sin. It also tells of God’s provision for forgiveness. Would you be able to present the gospel just using this chapter?
- C. Explain how Abraham’s faith relates to our faith and being counted for righteousness.
- D. God’s testing of Abraham prefigures Jesus’ sacrifice on the Cross. Explain how this is a crucial foundational truth of the Christian faith. Do you see a prefigure of Christ’s resurrection in this story?
- E. What character traits do you see in the story of Joseph? How could these traits be implemented in your life?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)